Story of Shahrzad

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visualization adn storytelling

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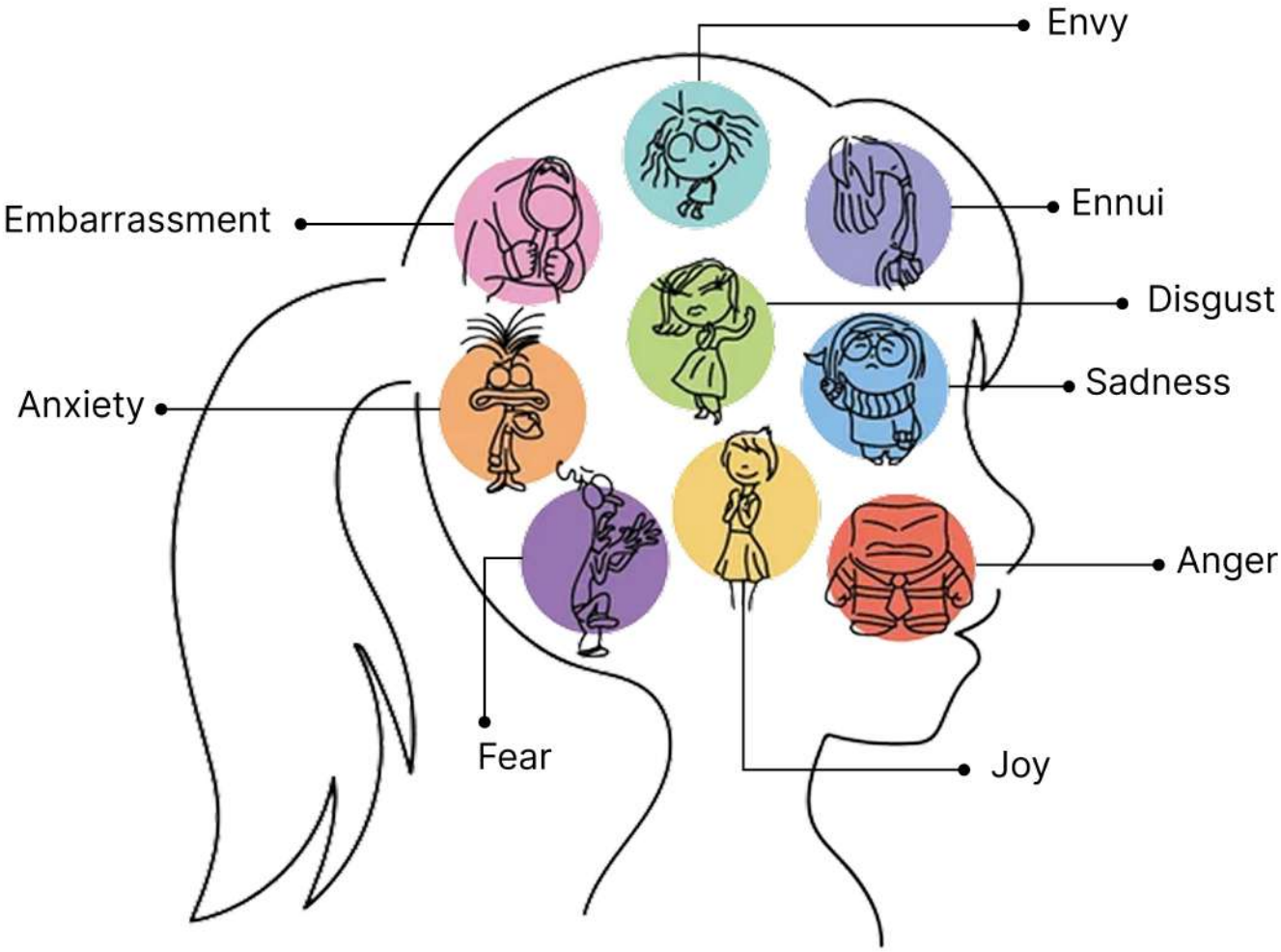
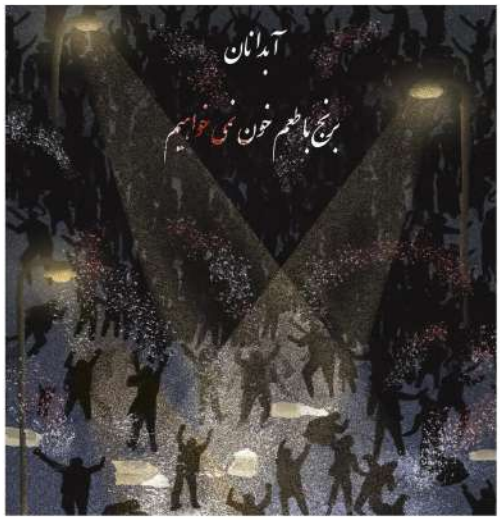
Shahrzad's Feelings



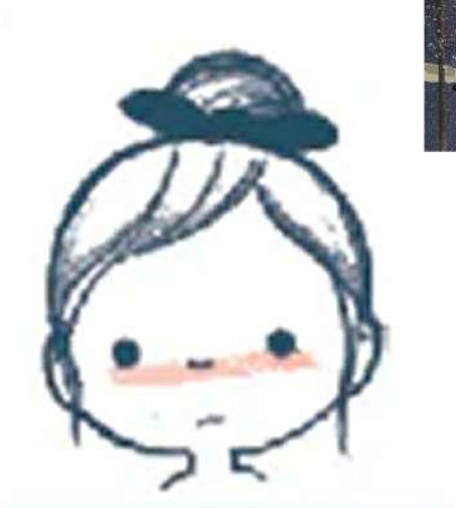
Shahrzad's Feelings

Shahrzad has recently immigrated from Iran to Canada as an international student.
She is excited to begin this new chapter of her journey.

Shahrzad's Feelings



People in Iran have begun protesting against the oppressive rule of the Islamic regime.
Shahrzad feels deep concern for the people in her homeland.



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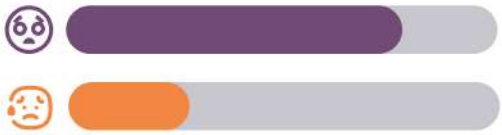
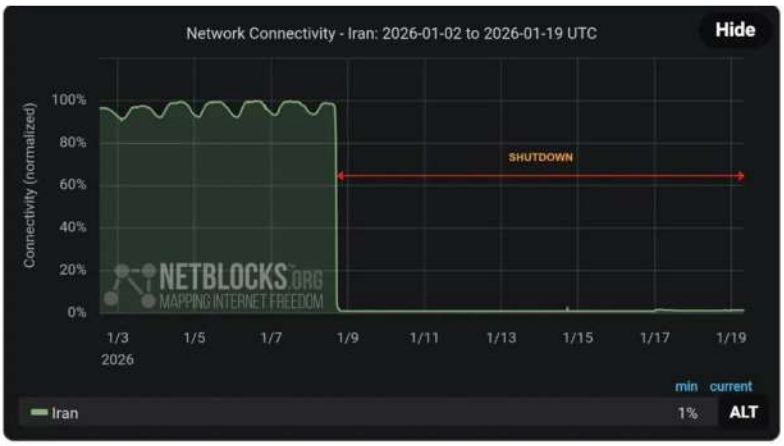
The Islamic Republic has deployed its armed forces to suppress the protests, and it has reportedly brought in thousands of foreign militia fighters to help quell the demonstrations.

Shahrzad's Feelings



The Islamic Republic has cut off people's access to the outside world, including shutting down the internet and disabling mobile networks and SIM cards. Shahrzad has lost contact with her family and friends.



Shahrzad's Feelings

Iran is under an internet blackout. Only a few people still have access to the international internet, and they are sharing disturbing footage of protesters who have been killed.

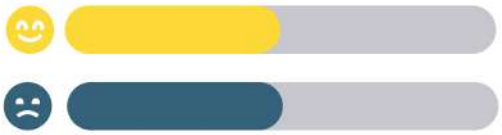
Shahrzad's Feelings

After some time, the internet gradually reconnects, and Shahrzad is finally able to call her friends and relatives again. She is relieved and happy to learn that they are safe.

Shahrzad's Feelings

Shahrzad learns that the Islamic regime has killed more than 20,000 civilians in just two days, including some of her friends and former classmates. It is one of the most horrific massacres in recent history.

Shahrzad's Feelings



The world has become aware of the Islamic Republic's crimes against humanity, and protests have begun across the globe in solidarity with Iran. Shahrzad and the people of Iran still hope for a better future for their country.

The End

1. Introduction & Topic

In this assignment, I wrote a story centered on Shahrzad, an Iranian international student living abroad who experiences the emotional and psychological impact of political unrest in her home country while being physically distant from it. Through her character, I explore how geographical distance does not lessen one's connection to homeland, identity, and loved ones. I chose this topic to emphasize that crimes against humanity occurring in Iran and around the world are not merely statistics or numbers reported in the media, but deeply painful human experiences that shape real lives. Behind every number, there are stories, memories, relationships, and emotions. By presenting these events through Shahrzad's personal perspective, I aimed to humanize political tragedy and show how such crises are profoundly intertwined with human nature, identity, and collective memory.

2. Story Format

The project is designed as a visual scrollytelling narrative that combines illustrated scenes with embedded data references, structured like a digital storyboard or interactive webpage through which the audience moves step by step. I intentionally chose this format to create emotional pacing rather than presenting events in a static way. The story begins with Shahrzad's calm academic life, gradually builds tension through internet disruption and isolation, moves into fear and uncertainty, then reaches a moment of shock upon learning about reported casualties, and finally shifts toward collective hope through global solidarity. This visual progression allows viewers to experience the emotional transformation alongside the character, encouraging them to feel the unfolding reality rather than simply read about it.

3. Initial Concept

In the first version of this project, I focused primarily on political facts and statistics related to protests and internet shutdowns. While the information was important, the narrative felt distant and impersonal. It read more like a news report than a human-centered data story. I realized that presenting numbers alone could not fully convey the emotional gravity of the situation, particularly for audiences who do not have a direct connection to Iran. The data was informative, but it lacked emotional resonance.

4. Adding Human Perspective

In the second iteration, I intentionally shifted the focus toward Shahrzad's lived experience. Rather than beginning with statistics, the story opened with her ordinary life as a student abroad, emphasizing routine, stability, and academic normalcy. The data element—specifically internet disruption—was introduced only at the moment it directly affected her ability to contact her family. This structural change established a clearer cause-and-effect relationship between political decisions and personal

consequences. By grounding the data in her experience, the story became more intimate, relatable, and emotionally engaging.

5. Emotional Arc & Global Response

In the final iteration, I strengthened the emotional arc by incorporating scenes of global protests and international awareness. This addition was significant because the purpose of the story is not solely to depict suffering, but also to highlight the importance of solidarity and collective responsibility. Ending the narrative with images of global support reframes the story from one of isolation to one of connection. It offers a sense of hope and shared humanity, creating a more meaningful and impactful conclusion for the audience.

6. Audience

The primary audience for this project includes human rights advocates and non-Iranian individuals who may be aware of events in Iran but do not fully grasp their personal and emotional impact. The assumed level of data literacy is that of the general public; therefore, the project avoids complex visualizations and instead relies on simple visual cues and a single, clear representation of internet shutdown patterns. The intention is not to overwhelm viewers with technical detail, but to cultivate empathy, awareness, and thoughtful engagement.

7. Conclusion

This storyboard seeks to demonstrate that political crises are not abstract events confined within national borders. They extend into classrooms, dorm rooms, and the everyday realities of students studying abroad. By combining emotional storytelling with selective and purposeful data references, the project emphasizes that behind every statistic are individuals experiencing fear, uncertainty, loss, and hope. Ultimately, the narrative underscores the significance of international attention and solidarity, suggesting that global awareness and collective voices can contribute to meaningful recognition and change.